

Earth's atmosphere. This is when the vibrations start because aerodynamic forces begin to act on the capsule and buffeting it around. Then, the drogue chute deploys, and you feel the shock of it. The main chute opens thereafter, and there is an even bigger jerk, before you finally splash down, feeling the huge unmistakable impact of the ship striking water.

Q. What were your thoughts when you splashed down?
I was happy that the parachutes deployed and told myself: well done, I am alive! Also that this was a mission well done. I was proud of the way we were able to conduct it. The science was done, 100 per cent of the objectives were achieved. And, obviously, there had been a huge learning in totality about the mission.

Q. When you got off the spacecraft, were you able to walk?
I thought I could, but I couldn't. That is because your body and mind forget how it is to walk in gravity again. You realise how much of an effort it is just to stand up. The body has to re-learn it. So, you take a step, you fall down. Somebody has to help you walk out. It takes a few days before you become okay with walking, and you are under observation for those few days. And then, gradually, they start your rehabilitation programme, wherein you start running and doing multi-axis activities to build you up. Around the seventh day, you are cleared for driving. But the changes in your body, like the muscle degeneration and the aerobic deconditioning, come back only after a period of time.

Q. Finally, what are your three big takeaways from the mission?
The biggest highlight for me was the sheer scale of collaboration it took to make such a mission happen. We travelled across the globe for our training and thousands of people sitting in different parts of the world came together to make this one mission happen. When you work together as a team for a common objective, you can do wonders.

Q. The second takeaway?
Though I am a trained fighter pilot, training to be an astronaut is very different in that you prepare for it for years together. We started training in 2020 and the mission happened only in 2025. For my colleagues going up in Gaganyaan, it may take longer. The sheer patience it takes to understand that the mundane is important for the exciting and that you need to keep at the grind for you to be doing that.

Q. And the third takeaway?
I would say that I did not imagine India would be so beautiful when you looked at it from space. Like Ricky sir (Rakesh Sharma) said, *Saare jahan se achha*. It is true.

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Q. How will your experience help the Gaganyaan project that aims to carry three or four astronauts into orbit in the next couple of years?
Human space missions are extremely complex and challenging. ISRO has been working extensively and very diligently on making this mission happen. But the technologies and confidence levels you need in your systems are of a different magnitude. A lot of things are available on the internet, but when you are part of that activity, you learn things that are not available in books. I have brought these experiences with me; we have already formalised the process by which we are putting them back into the system. We have to tell them that this is what we need to relook at or this is great. All these kinds of discussions have already started. My mission serves very well the grand vision of India sending humans into space. It is a catapult or stepping stone to achieve that. Because when we do, we will have an Indian capsule launched from Indian soil going to space and coming back. It will be a huge accomplishment for us as a nation.